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COMMERCIAL AEROSPACE

# NASA awards Momentus contract for solar sail demonstration study

The technology is intended to enable space weather-monitoring satellites to operate closer to the Sun, providing earlier warning of solar events such as geomagnetic storms.

Jamie Whitney March 19, 2026 2 min read

## Key Highlights

- The project involves a 1,652-square-meter solar sail, developed jointly by NASA and NOAA, to improve space weather monitoring.
- Solar sails generate propulsion from sunlight, eliminating the need for conventional fuel and enabling longer, more efficient space missions.
- NASA may award additional contracts for further study or demonstration based on the success of this initial project.

**SAN JOSE, Calif. -** Momentus Inc. in San Jose, Calif., announced it was awarded a contract by the National Aeronautics and Space Administration (NASA) to support the Space Storms Solar Sail Sentinel Demonstration Study for a potential mission based on the company's cislunar-capable Vigoride spacecraft platform. Momentus completed the study and submitted its final report to NASA under a 2025 contract.

NASA may consider awarding a follow-on contract for additional study or a flight demonstration through the Flight Opportunities program, managed at NASA's Armstrong Flight Research Center in Edwards, Calif. The proposed solar sail would measure 1,652 square meters (17,782 square feet), roughly one-third the size of a football field. For a flight demonstration, the selected hosted orbital platform provider would be responsible for spacecraft bus functions and system integration of the solar sail technologies provided by NASA.

### Sail study

The study focused on a solar sail developed jointly by NASA and the National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration (NOAA) in Silver Spring, Md. The technology is intended to enable space weather-monitoring satellites to operate closer to the Sun, providing earlier warning of solar events such as geomagnetic storms. By measuring solar wind, including magnetic field and plasma, at greater distances from Earth, the system could extend response times for critical space weather impacts.

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Solar sails generate propulsion by using radiation pressure from sunlight, eliminating the need for conventional propellant. The proposed mission would demonstrate controlled maneuvering and navigation using solar sail propulsion.

"Momentus is proud to support this next-gen solar sail mission study with our Vigoride Orbital Service Vehicle. Vigoride's modular design enables us to rapidly integrate complex diverse hosted mission payloads," said John Rood, CEO of Momentus. "We're pleased to again be entrusted by NASA to perform cutting-edge work to unlock new frontiers in space-based systems. We're excited to help usher in a new era where solar sail propulsion provides new orbital capabilities."

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Jamie Whitney joined the staff of *Military & Aerospace Electronics* in 2018 and oversees editorial content and...

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